

HARNESSING THE LIFE FORCE

mesmerism and hypnosis

The word *mesmerism* comes from an 18th-century German doctor, Franz Mesmer. He championed the belief that all life forms, animal and vegetable, possessed a magnetic energy or fluid, and that, influenced by the planets, this energy acted much like the tides. He believed that illnesses were created by blockages of the energy's normal movements, and therefore that the deft use of magnets applied by someone who possessed powerful personal magnetism—such as Mesmer himself—could cure ailments. He called this transfer of energy, which in time included inanimate objects, “animal magnetism.”

▼ Fixed eye contact

Mesmer was in thrall to the notion of magnetic forces, visible in this image, that could be passed to and from willing subjects, bringing them under his benevolent power.



Trance and atmosphere

Mesmer developed his theory in Vienna. But it was in Paris after 1778 that he elaborated it fully and gained his greatest fame. At its heart was a semi-mystical trancelike state that Mesmer induced in his patients as he fixated them with a penetrating gaze while manipulating and squeezing parts of their bodies. If successful, a series of hysterical

convulsions followed. This was the “crisis,” the moment when the ailment was cured and a natural equilibrium restored.

Mesmer's popularity was such that, rather than turn away his clients, almost all drawn from the higher reaches of society, he saw them in groups of 20 or more. These



sessions were as much theatrical as medical. The patients would be grouped around the *baquet* (see opposite); the lighting low; the silence broken only by distant, almost celestial music.

Mesmer, often clad in a long, lavender robe, passed among his patients, touching, pointing, directing, and gazing intently. Periodically, a patient would enter a state of catalepsy, apparently frozen, or would violently twitch and sob, laugh

“This system sheds new light upon the nature of fire and of light, as well as on the theory of attraction ...”

FRANZ MESMER ON ANIMAL MAGNETISM, 1779